

# ELECTION 2009

## Cover story

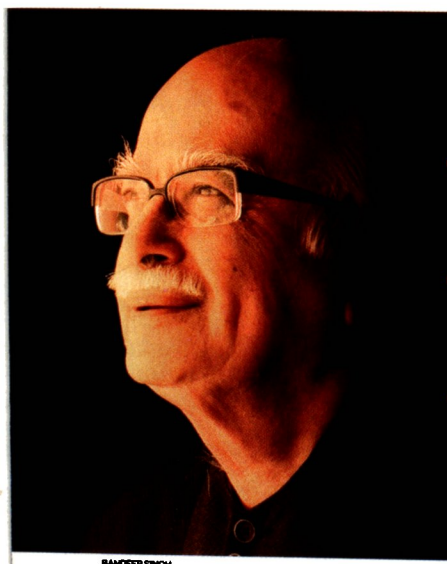
L.K.ADVANI

marked the end of power and the beginning of the pathology of defeat. The compulsive *yatri*, even in the wilderness of hopelessness, was looking for greener destinations, and he found one in the unlikelyst of places, across the border: Jinnah's mausoleum in Karachi. It was an adventure no Indian nationalist worth his nation would have dared to undertake. His rediscovery of the secular soul of the founder of the Islamic republic was audacious as well as suicidal, but the traveller was destined to move on, even as the party he built abandoned him and he himself thought that was the end of the road. He would survive, and the party would unanimously choose him as the candidate most suitable for regaining India. Obviously, Lal Krishna Advani needs a mode of transport speedier than a chariot powered by a Toyota engine. For the first time in the life of a man whose travails and travels paralleled the evolution of independent India, the one destination that eluded him falls within his sight. It is now or never.

The 'now' is steeped in the quiet confidence of an 81-year-old man who defies the limits of both biology and ideology as he turns the struggle of a lifetime into a battle for retrieving India from the twin evils of a "weak prime minister" and an "extra-constitutionally powerful dynasty". As he leans back in the plush seat of his campaign jet, enjoying his favourite flavoured milk, it is the confidence of having finally become the singular leader of the party—a leader who for once is not fighting against power but is fighting for it. And when power was BJP's to squander away, he was the proverbial number two, an identity that would grow into an existential crisis. Looming above him—and above the party as well—was one of India's most indulged prime ministers, the 'human face' of BJP, the Dubcek of Indian Right. Now that Atal Bihari Vajpayee is in retire-

ADVANI MARCHES ON TO THE BEAT OF HIS OWN DRUM AT A RALLY IN MAHARASHTRA





### S

- Biggest **STRENGTHS** are his honesty, clean public image and over 60 years of experience.
- Great organiser and strategist with a sharp analytical mind, who drives a hard bargain.
- Leads from the front and converted the poll into an Advani vs the rest presidential battle.

### W

- Is easily swayed by uninformed opinion, which remains his primary **WEAKNESS**.
- Retreats into a shell under pressure and has very strong likes and dislikes.
- Talks with determination but has seldom shown that he can carry his will through.

### O

- Best **OPPORTUNITY** lies in the divisions within the UPA where allies are jumping ship.
- Split in anti-BJP vote likely as many UPA allies do not agree on common candidates.
- Hopes that if NDA gets more seats than UPA, the political "trapeze artists" will return.

BANDHEEP SINGH